

## Sonnet 19: When I consider how my light is spent

HSE72 -A

BY JOHN MILTON

When I consider how my light is spent,  
Ere half my days, in this dark world and wide,  
And that one Talent which is death to hide  
Lodged with me useless, though my Soul more bent  
To serve therewith my Maker, and present  
My true account, lest he returning chide;  
“Doth God exact day-labour, light denied?”  
I fondly ask. But patience, to prevent  
That murmur, soon replies, “God doth not need  
Either man’s work or his own gifts; who best  
Bear his mild yoke, they serve him best. His state  
Is Kingly. Thousands at his bidding speed  
And post o’er Land and Ocean without rest:  
They also serve who only stand and wait.”

### Facts about the Author

- John Milton (1608 – 1674)
- Best known for his epic poem *Paradise Lost* (1667).
- Writing in English, Latin, and Italian
- *Areopagitica* (1644): most influential and impassioned defences of freedom of speech
- His first published poem was “On Shakespeare” (1630), anonymously included in the Second Folio edition of William Shakespeare’s plays in 1632.
- William Blake saw himself as Milton’s poetical son.

### Facts about the Poem

- The sonnet was first published in **Milton’s 1673 Poems** in his autograph notebook, known as the “**Trinity Manuscript**”
- It is popularly given the title ‘On His Blindness’, but there is no evidence that Milton used this title
- This title was assigned a century later by **Thomas Newton** in his 1761 edition of Milton’s poetry,

- Milton gave it the number **19**, but in the published book it was numbered **16**
- it was **composed** sometime between June and October 1655
- Written in the form of **Petrarchan sonnet**
- Unlike most Petrarchan sonnets, the conflicts here arise from religious faith rather than erotic love.
- This poem focuses on the **speaker’s internal conflicts**
- Blasphemous idea—that God requires work, rather than faith
- **The last line** is particularly well known “They also serve who only stand and wait”,
- The Navy Wives Clubs of America uses the motto “They Also Serve, Who Stay and Wait”.
- **Form, Metre and Rhyme**
- **Form**
- It is Petrarchan sonnet
- Petrarchan sonnets are often argumentative poems
- Small poem of fourteen lines
- it is divided into two parts:
  - the octave ( 8 lines) - Poets often propose an idea or a position
  - the sestet ( 6 lines) - They turn around and critique or correct that idea.
- All Petrarchan sonnets have a “volta” or a “turn.”
- **VOLTA** - Italian word for “turn.”
- In a sonnet, the volta is the turn of thought or argument:
- In Petrarchan or Italian sonnets it occurs between the octave and the sestet
- In Shakespearean or English before the final couplet.
- In this poem it comes a little early: midway through line eight

- **Metre**
  - It is written in iambic pentameter. (Unstressed Stressed (5 combination))
  - And **post** o'er **Land** and **Ocean** **without** **rest**:
  - They **also** **serve** who **only** **stand** and **wait**.
  - **Rhyme scheme**
  - It follows a standard Petrarchan rhyme scheme
  - ABBA ABBA CDE CDE
  - **Vocabulary**
  - **Light** (Line 1) - Vision, eyesight. Here the speaker is referring to the capacity to perceive light: in other words, the speaker can't see.
  - **Ere** (Line 2) - Before. In some contexts, the word also connotes "early."
  - **Lodged** (Line 4) - Living with, containing. In other words, the speaker's "Talent" is part of who the speaker is.
  - **Bent** (Line 4) - Hoping, desiring, wishing. The word suggests the shape of the speaker's soul, or the direction it tends to move in—as though the speaker's soul has been physically bent in its efforts to please God.
  - **Chide** (Line 6) - To scold or punish.
  - **Day-labour** (Line 7) - Most likely this refers to work done during the day—that is, work that requires light to complete. Milton coined this word, so its exact definition is a matter of interpretation.
  - **Fondly** (Line 8) here takes the meaning of the time as 'foolishly optimistic'.
  - **Murmur** (Line 9) - A low or quiet complaint. The word is one of Milton's favorites; he often uses it in his later poems to describe unholy, impious responses.
  - **Yoke** (Line 11) - A burden or obligation. The word literally describes a device that farmers would use to attach oxen to a cart or plow, so that as the oxen walked forward, they would pull that cart or plow behind them
  - **Post** (Line 13) - To move swiftly; to travel with haste and urgency.
  - **O'er** (Line 13) - A shortened form of the word "over." Milton makes the contraction for the sake of his meter, so it should be pronounced as a single syllable.
- Poetic Devices**
- **Alliteration:** The repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words or stressed syllables
  - Line 2: "d," "d," "w," "w"
  - Line 4: "m," "m," "m"
  - Line 5: "m," "M"
  - Line 7: "d," "l," "l," "d"
  - Line 8: "p," "p"
  - Line 10: "b"
  - Line 11: "B," "s," "b," "s"
  - Line 12: "s"
  - Line 13: "o," "O"
  - Line 14: "s," "o," "s"
  - **Assonance** : The repetition of vowel sounds across a line of text or poetry
  - Line 1: "I," "i," "i," "i"
  - • Line 2: "i," "i," "i"
  - • Line 3: "A," "a," "a," "i," "i," "i"
  - • Line 6: "e," "e," "i"
  - • Line 7: "o," "o," "a," "a," "ou," "i," "i"
  - • Line 8: "o," "e," "e," "e"
  - • Line 9: "u," "u," "o," "o," "o"
  - • Line 10: "o," "o"
  - • Line 11: "i"
  - • Line 12: "I," "i," "i"
  - • Line 13: "o," "o," "a," "a," "O"
  - • Line 14: "a," "a," "a"
  - **Enjambment** : Enjambment is the continuation of a sentence or clause across a line break.
  - • Lines 1-2: "spent, / Ere"
  - • Lines 2-3: "wide, / And"
  - • Lines 3-4: "hide /

- • Lines 4-5: “bent / To”
- • Lines 5-6: “present / My”
- • Lines 6-7: “chide; / “Doth”
- • Lines 8-9: “prevent / That”
- • Lines 9-10: “need / Either”
- • Lines 10-11: “best / Bear”
- • Lines 11-12: “state / Is”
- • Lines 12-13: “ speed / And”
- **End stopped line:** a line of poetry in which a sentence or phrase comes to a conclusion at the end of the line.
- Line 7: “denied?”
- Line 13: “rest:”
- Line 14: “wait.”
- **Caesura:** A stop or pause in a metrical line, often marked by punctuation or by a grammatical boundary, such as a phrase or clause.
- • Line 2: “,”
- • Line 4: “,”
- • Line 5: “,”
- • Line 6: “,”
- • Line 7: “,”
- • Line 8: “.” “,”
- • Line 9: “,” “,”
- • Line 10: “,”
- • Line 11: “,” “,”
- • Line 12: “.”
- **Allusions:** An allusion in a poem refers to a **person, place, historical event, or ancient source** such as the Bible, mythology, ancient poets etc.
- Line 1: “When I consider how my light is spent”
- the speaker’s loss of “light” as an allusion to the **Parable of the Ten Virgins**, in the Book of Matthew, 25:1-12.
- In the Parable, Jesus compares the “Kingdom of Heaven ... unto **ten virgins**, which took their lamps, and went forth to meet the bridegroom.”
- However, five of them, “foolish virgins,” forget to take oil with them for their lamps; when the “bridegroom” comes in the middle of the night, they can’t light their lamps and go out to meet him.
- Line 3: “And that one Talent which is death to hide”
- It reveals that the speaker has “one Talent” and that it would be “death to hide” it.
- This is a reference to the **Parable of the Talents**, which follows immediately on the Parable of the Ten Virgins in the Book of Matthew, 25:14-30.
- In this parable, a rich man goes traveling. Before he leaves his home, he divides his property among his servants (using units of biblical money, called “talents”), instructing them to invest it wisely. Two of them do so, increasing the value of their master’s property while he’s gone. But the third simply buries his talent in the ground. The master punishes him severely for his failure.
- Line 11: “his mild yoke”
- The speaker describes God’s “yoke” as “mild,”
- Here, the speaker is closely paraphrasing the Book of Matthew 11:30, where Jesus states, “For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.”
- Lines 12-13: “Thousands at his bidding speed / And post o’er Land and Ocean”
- In this line 12, the speaker alludes to Psalm 68:17 and Zechariah 1:10,
- Both of which describe the enormous energy of God’s servants on Earth and the intensity of their activity.
- **Personification :** Personification is a poetic device where animals, plants or even inanimate objects, are given human qualities
- In line 7, a figure called “patience” appears in the poem. The rest of the poem constitutes patience’s response to the speaker



**MCQs**

1. In this poem Milton's central concern is .....

**Faith and relationship with God**

2. Who are God's best servants according to Milton?

**Those who are obediently follow the will and wishes of God**

3. On his Blindness is also known as

**When I consider how my light is spent**

4. The sonnet was first published in

**Trinity Manuscript**

5. 'Thousands at His bidding speed And post o'er land and ocean without rest' Whom do Milton mention here?

**Angels**

6. When Milton became blind, his ability to ..... was threatened.

**Write**

7. Who assigned the Title "On his Blindness" to Milton's Sonnet 19

**Tomas Newton**

8. What is the rhyme scheme of the poem

**Abba abba cde cde**

9. Who saved Milton from his dilemma in the poem On His Blindness

**Patience**

10. What was the theme of Milton's sonnet On His Blindness

**Laments his blindness**

11. The concluding six lines of the poem are called

**Sestet**

12. The Opening eight lines of the poem are called

**Octave**

13. At what age did Milton become completely blind?

**43**

14. 'My light is spent' means

**Loss of eyesight**

15. What is John Milton's One Talent mentioned in the poem

**Ability to write poetry**

16. Milton's 'On His Blindness' is a .....

**Sonnet**

17. Identify figures of speech in 'who best / bear his mild yoke'

**Oxymoron**

18. Milton, thou shouldn't be living at this hour. England has need of thee" - Who says this

**William Wordsworth in London (1802)**

19. When Milton wrote this sonnet

**1652**

20. What does Milton mean by 'era half of my day'

**1. He is talking of his golden period**

- 2. He became blind in the middle of his life and totally blind in 1652 at the age of 43**

21. Which is death to hide' . What does Milton mean here?

**To hid the gift or to keep useless is death to him**

22. What does Milton's soul want

**To serve god by writing great poetry**

23. Lest the returning chide, How does the line allude to the Biblical Story of talents?

**The master in the parable of talent rebukes the servant for keeping his talent (gold coin) useless**

24. Identify the figure of speech 'But Patience to prevent that murmur'

**Personification**

25. What is Milton's question to God?

**If god would demand active service form his when he has denied the light of his eyes**

26. What does word ' post o' ver land' mean?

**Travel**